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THE CHILD

PREMCHAND

INTRODUCTION

Munshi Premchand (1880-1936) was an Indian author of numerous novels and stories in Hindi and Urdu. He was considered foremost among the writers in Hindi and Urdu in the early part of the twentieth century. He pioneered in adapting Indian themes to western literary styles. The noted Indian film-maker Satyajit Ray made a famous feature film from Premchand's short story, *Shatranj Ke Khiladi.*

He was the first Hindi writer to introduce realism in his writings.

TEXT

People call Gangu a Brahmin. He considers himself one, too. All my other servants bow to me. But Gangu never greets me like this. Probably he expects me to bow to him. He never touches any of the used utensils. I lack the courage to ask him even to fan me in the hot weather. Sometimes when nobody else is around and I am dripping with perspiration, he does pick up a fan, but his attitude is that he is doing me a great favour. He is short-tempered and cannot tolerate even the slightest rebuke. He has very few friends and considers it below his dignity to sit with the syce or the bearer. I have never seen him being friendly with anyone. Nor does he ever go to a fair or a

show. He is not even fond of *bhang*, which is a common addiction amongst people of his class.

He never prays: nor does he go for a bath in the river; and he is completely illiterate. Yet he expects all the respect due to a Brahmin.

Why shouldn't he? If other people can claim respect on the basis of wealth left to them by their forefathers, surely Gangu can also claim respect on account of his ancestry.

I do not talk to my servants except when it is necessary. They have strict instructions not to invade my privacy unless they are sent for. Such small matters as getting a glass of water, or putting on the shoes, or lighting the lamp, I prefer to do myself rather than send for them. It gives me a feeling of independence and self-reliance. The servants know my habits by now and they seldom bother me.

If ever they pay an unsolicited visit to me it is either that they want an advance against their salary or that they wish to complain about other servants. Both these practices I consider reprehensible. When I pay them regularly and enough I do not see any reason why they should finish a month's salary in fifteen days. And backbiting I consider a sign of weakness or a mode of flattery both of which are ignoble.

One morning Gangu came to me without being sent for. I felt annoyed and asked him, irritably, what he had come for. From Gangu's face it appeared that he wanted to say something but in spite of his best efforts the words refused to come to the lips. I said again after a little pause, 'What is the matter? Why don't you speak out? You know it is getting late for my morning walk.' Gangu replied, haltingly, 'Please do not delay yourself. I shall come some other time.' This was worse, I knew. Now that I was in a hurry, Gangu would have cut short his tale. If he came when he thought I had more leisure he would perhaps waste my time for hours. He only considered me busy when I was reading or writing. When he found me just alone, sitting in a contemplative mood, he thought that I was merely idling. And it was almost certain that he would inflict himself on me in one of those moments, little realizing how precious they were for me.

I wanted to dispose of him right then and said, 'If you have come for an advance, you can rest assured that you will not get it.'

'I do not want an advance,' said Gangu, 'I have never asked you for one.'

'Then you must be wanting to complain against someone,' I said. 'You know how I hate backbiting.'

'No sir,' said Gangu, 'I have no complaints against any one.'

'What have you come to bother me about then?' I asked impatiently.

Gangu made another attempt to disclose his secret. I could see from his face that he was trying to muster up strength to do it. At last he said, 'I wish to be relieved of my duties, sir. I shall not be able to serve you any longer.'

This was the first request of its kind and I felt hurt. I was considered an ideal employer and the servants thought it their good fortune to stay on with me. 'Why do you want to leave?' I asked.

'You are the image of kindness, sir,' said Gangu. 'Who would want to leave you unless there was a very good reason? I find myself in a situation which leaves me with no other alternative. I do not want people to raise their fingers at you on my account.'

This was most intriguing. I forgot all about my morning walk and seating myself in a chair, said, 'Why do you talk in riddles? Why don't you say clearly what is on your mind?' Gangu replied haltingly again: 'Sir, the thing is that ... that woman who has just been turned out of the Widows' Home ... that Gomti Devi...' and he stopped without finishing the sentence. I asked impatiently, 'What has she to do with your job?'

'I want to marry her, sir,' said Gangu.

I looked at him in sheer bewilderment. How had this old-fashioned Brahmin, who had not even been touched by modern civilization, decided to marry a woman, whom no self-respecting man would even allow near his house? Gomti had created quite a stir in the placid atmosphere of our *mohalla*. She had entered the Widows' Home some years ago. Twice the Home authorities had got her married off but both times she had come back after a week or so. Ultimately the Home had decided to expel her. She had now taken a room in the *mohalla* and was an object of great interest to all the lovelorn young men.

I felt both annoyed with and sympathetic towards Gangu. 'Why couldn't this stupid man find another woman to marry?' I said to myself, I was certain that she would not stick to him for more than a few days. If he had been better off financially, she might have stuck on for six months or so but now I was sure the marriage would not last more than a few days.

'Are you aware of her past?' I asked him.

'It's all lies, sir,' he said with great conviction. 'People have given her a bad name for nothing.'

'What nonsense!' I said, 'Can you deny that she has left three husbands?'

'What could she do,' replied Gangu unperturbed, 'if those people turned her out?'

'What a fool you are!' I added, 'Can you really believe that a man comes all the way to marry a woman, spends thousands of rupees on the marriage, only to turn her out in the end?'

Gangu replied almost with the zeal of a poet, 'Where there is no love, you cannot expect a woman to stay on. You cannot win a woman with mere board and lodging. Those people who married her thought that they were doing her a great favour by marrying a widow and took it for granted that she would do everything for their sake. But to win someone over one has first to forget about oneself. And besides, sir, she gets fits, sometimes, starts talking all sorts of nonsense and becomes unconscious. People say that she is under the influence of a witch.'

'And you want to marry such a woman,' I said. 'Don't you realize that you are asking for trouble?'

Gangu replied in the tone of a martyr, 'God willing, I shall make something of myself, if I get her.'

'So you have decided finally,' I asked him.

'Yes, sir,' he replied.

All right,' I said, 'in that case I accept your resignation.'

Normally, I don't believe in old customs and meaningless traditions. In this particular case, however, I considered it definitely dangerous to keep in the house a man who was intent on marrying a woman of such doubtful reputation. It might lead to all sorts of complications. To my mind, Gangu, in marrying this woman, was behaving like a starving man. That the piece of bread was dry and tasteless was immaterial to him. I considered it wise to keep aloof.

Five months passed. Gangu had married Gomti and was living in the same *mohalla* in a thatched hut. He was now earning a living as a hawker. Whenever I met him on the road, I stopped to enquir about his welfare. His life was a matter of great interest to me. I was impatient to know how it would all end. However, I always found him happy. His face had a glow which had only comes with complete lack of worry. He earned about a rupee every day. After buying his stock, he was left with about ten annas or so. There must have been some supernatural power in those ten annas to give him such completed contentment.

One day I heard that Gomti had run away. I don't know why, but this gave me a great pleasure. It was perhaps that Gangu's self-confidence and ease had always made me envious. I was happy that I had been proved right, after all. He would now realize that the people who had dissuaded him from marrying Gomti were really his well-wishers. 'What a fool he was,' I thought to myself, 'to consider marrying Gomti a matter of good fortune, even to consider it as entering paradise.' I was impatient to meet him.

He looked completely shattered when I met him that afternoon. Seeing me he started to cry and said, 'Babuji, Gomti has left me.'

I replied with feigned sympathy, 'I told you in the beginning to keep away from her but you did not listen. Has she taken away your belongings also?'

Gangu put his hands on his heart as if I had blasphemed and said, 'Don't say that, Babuji, she hasn't taken a thing. Her own stuff is still lying here. I don't know what shortcomings she found in me that she decided to leave. I am sure I wasn't good enough for her. She was educated and I am an absolute illiterate. If I could have stayed on with her a little longer she would have made a man out of me. Whatever she might have been for other men, for me she was definitely a goddess. I must have been at fault somewhere that she decided to leave.'

I was most disappointed at Gangu's words. I had been certain that he would tell me a tale of faithlessness on the part of Gomti and that I would have to show sympathy towards him. But it seemed that this fool still had his eyes closed or perhaps he had lost his sense of perception. I said, half in jest, 'So she hasn't taken away anything from the house!'

'No, not even a penny's worth.'

'And she loved you very much?'

'What more can I say Babuji? I shall not forget her till I die.'

'And yet she decided to leave you?'

'This is what surprises me.'

'Have you ever heard the old saying, 'Frailty, thy name is woman'.'

'Oh, don't say that, Babuji. I would never for a moment believe that in respect of her.'

'Then go and find her out if you are still so attached to her.'

'Yes, master, I won't get any respite till I have found her. If only I knew where to look for her! I am certain that she will come back

to me. I must go and search for her. I will see you when I come back if I am still alive.' And saying this he went away.

After this incident I had to go to Nainital, and returned after nearly a month. I had barely taken off my clothes when I saw Gangu standing with a new-born baby. He was bursting with joy. Even Nanda could not have felt such joy at getting Krishna. His face had the same glow that appears on the face of a starved man after a full meal. I asked him again in jest, 'Have you had any news of Gomti Devi? I believe you went in search of her.' Gangu said, beaming with joy, 'I have found her at last, Babuji. She was in the Women's Hospital in Lucknow. She had told a friend here that if I was very upset I should be informed about her whereabouts. As soon as I heard it I went to Lucknow and brought her back. I have also got this child in the bargain.' He showed me the child almost with the pride of an athlete showing off a newly won medal.

I was surprised at his shamelessness. He had not been married to Gomti for more than six months and yet he was displaying the child with great pride. I said tauntingly, 'Oh, so you have got a boy also. That is perhaps why she ran away. Are you sure this is your child?'

'Why mine, Babuji, it is God's.'

'It was born in Lucknow, wasn't it?'

'Yes, Babuji, it was a month old only yesterday.'

'How long have you been married?'

'This is the seventh month.'

'So this child was born within six months of your marriage.'

'Yes,' said Gangu, undisturbed.

And still you consider it your child?'

'Yes, sir.'

Are you in your senses?' I asked. I was not quite certain whether he did not understand what I was trying to hint at or whether he was intentionally misunderstanding me.

'She had a very difficult time,' said Gangu in the same tone. 'It is almost a new life for her, Babuji. For full three days and three nights she was in pain. Oh, it was unbearable.'

This was the point for me to interrupt and I said, 'This is the first time I have heard of a child being born within six months of marriage.'

This question surprised Gangu; he said with an impish smile, 'This has never bothered me. This was the reason perhaps why

Gomti had left the house. I told her that if she did not love me she could leave me by all means and I would never bother her again. But if she did love me she must not let the child separate us. I would love it as my own. After all, when one takes a harvested field one does not refuse the crop merely because someone else has grown it.

He gave a hearty laugh.

I was most touched by Gangu's sentiments and felt an utter fool. I extended my hands, took the child from Gangu and kissed it. Gangu said, 'Babuji, you are the embodiment of goodness. I often talk to Gomti about you and have many times asked her to come and pay her respects to you. But she is so bashful.'

I, the embodiment of goodness! My middle-class morality stood ashamed at Gangu's courage and sincerity.

'You are the embodiment of goodness,' I said, 'and this child adds charm to it. Let me come with you and meet Gomti.' And we both went to Gangu's house.

GLOSSARY/NOTES

Syce: person in charge of horses
Blaspheme: to use words which show a lack of self-respect for God or religion
Bashful: tending to feel uncomfortable with others; shy

COMPREHENSION

A. Answer these questions in about 20 words.

1. Why did Gangu leave his job?
2. What is your impression of Gomti?
3. Comment on the title of the story.

B. Answer these questions in 50-60 words.

1. Describe the character of Gangu?
2. Why has Gangu been described as the embodiment of goodness?
3. 'She had a very difficult time.' Why do you think it was 'difficult' for her? Justify your answer.
4. Comment on the appropriateness of the title of this story.
5. 'He gave a hearty langh.' What are the reasons for his 'hearty laugh'?